

how prestigious the employer. And educational internships, he said, are rare. You're much better off applying for paying jobs than for unpaid internships. "Don't sell yourself short. Try and get a real job that pays a decent wage," he said.

This is just one lawyer's opinion. But it's such a complex decision when you're a young person making it. A big reason not to do an unpaid internship, in my opinion, would be to show companies that having unpaid internships won't get them great interns (like you). That's a noble long-game and requires selflessness. For example, the main complainant in the *Black Swan* suit, Eric Glatt, was 42 years old and had enough money that he knew he could do the internship, see what the conditions really were, and then sue to try and make things better for all interns. But not everyone can be like him.

It's hard for me to tell you not to do an unpaid internship when I did one—even though it caused my finances (and psyche) deep damage and furthered my belief that offering them later creates a very narrow, white/upper-class employee pool, which does not benefit any company. I *would* absolutely advise you not to pay for college credits from another university so you can hemorrhage money on an unpaid internship. That was not smart of me. What I can tell you is:

BE OPEN-MINDED. My first mistake was being so dead set on one specific place to intern and basing all my self-worth on its prestige. If you're more open-minded, you won't feel that one offer is do-or-die, the way I did about *The Daily Show*. It's not like I spent all summer becoming Jon Stewart's best friend. Don't get too lost in the clouds about what the internship might look like before you've even arrived at the office.

DON'T BELIEVE THAT YOUR ENTIRE CAREER BEGINS AND ENDS WITH THIS INTERNSHIP. Have multiple options in your back pocket. One could be this unpaid internship: you want to see if you can make it work. One could be a paid internship somewhere else. One could be finding a paying gig in retail or as a lifeguard for the summer so you have more money to spend on your passion projects during the school year. One could be looking for a gig as a counselor on a traveling summer program like Teen Tours or Birthright (I'm *so* Jewish) so you can work for money AND get to see the world. If I'd been more open to other options (like staying in Boston for the summer or looking for a paid job near my parents' house in sunny Fort Lauderdale), I could have avoided a lot of stress and spent less cash.

